

Chicago Tribune



\$4.00 | FRIDAY, APRIL 3, 2026 | CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Fierce Trump backer Bondi fired

Attorney general didn't quell furor on Epstein or bring trials against president's perceived enemies

By Alanna Durkin Richer, Eric Tucker, Michael Balsamo and Michelle L. Price
ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON — President Donald Trump said Thursday that Pam Bondi is out as his attorney general, ending the contentious

tenure of a loyalist who upended the Justice Department's culture of independence from the White House, oversaw large-scale firings of career employees and moved aggressively to investigate the Republican president's perceived enemies. The departure followed months

of scrutiny over the Justice Department's handling of files related to the Jeffrey Epstein sex trafficking investigation and failed efforts to meet Trump's unwavering demands for criminal cases against his adversaries. As Trump's own frustrations mounted, he began privately discussing firing Bondi, people familiar with the matter say.



Bondi

"Pam Bondi is a Great American Patriot and a loyal friend, who faithfully served as my Attorney General over the past year," Trump said in a statement. He added: "We love Pam, and she will be transitioning to a much needed and important new job in the private sector, to be announced at a date in the near future."

Trump named Deputy Attorney General Todd Blanche, one of his former personal lawyers, as the acting attorney general. Three people familiar with the matter told The Associated Press on Thursday that he has privately discussed Lee Zeldin, head of the Environmental Protection Agency, as a permanent pick.

In her own statement, Bondi

See **BONDI** on Page A9



CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

'I no longer have my child'

Dionne Mhooon, mother of slain Chicago police Officer Aréanah Preston, stands in the lobby of the Leighton Criminal Court Building in Chicago on Thursday after a plea deal for one of the defendants accused of killing Preston in May 2023. Joseph Brooks, 22, pleaded guilty to murder and was sentenced to 55 years in prison, the first of four defendants charged to have his case resolved. Trevell Breeland, Jakwon Buchanan and Jaylan Frazier are still facing pending charges in the slaying of the officer. **Chicagoland, Page A3**

Company told to finish asphalt spill cleanup

By Christiana Freitag
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Illinois officials have secured a court order requiring a petroleum storage company to resume cleanup of a major asphalt spill in the Chicago Sanitary and Ship

Canal after federal regulators ended their oversight in November.

Over a year ago, half a million gallons of liquid asphalt spilled into the canal near Forest View. The U.S. Environmental Protection Agency initially oversaw the

remediation efforts, removing more than 2,000 tons of material before it stepped away from enforcing further cleanup efforts.

An Illinois Environmental Protection Agency review of the site in December found toxic sludge still in the waterway, and

state officials became concerned the cleanup had been ended prematurely.

In March, Illinois Attorney General Kwame Raoul filed a lawsuit alleging the St. Louis-

See **SPILL** on Page A4

CHICAGO PUBLIC SCHOOLS

Dearth of Latino leaders grows

Official's departure comes amid calls for more representation

By Kate Armanini
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Alfonso Carmona, the second-in-command of Chicago Public Schools, is stepping down Friday as acting chief education officer — less than a week after the appointment of CPS CEO Macqueline King and amid calls for greater Latino representation in her cabinet.

Carmona accepted a superintendent position in Lake County in November, which begins in July. Though CPS has not announced his official departure date, Carmona confirmed to the Tribune that Friday will be his last day.

A Colombian immigrant and 22-year veteran of CPS, Carmona has been one of the district's most prominent Latino leaders. His departure leaves a top role vacant during a key transition period for the district.

A CPS spokesperson said the district intends to fill Carmona's role "as soon as possible."

Recent leadership shake-ups at CPS have resurfaced long-standing questions about race and representation in the nation's fourth-largest school district. Almost half of the district's 315,000 students are Latino, and about a third are Black.

On Wednesday, a coalition of school board members, elected

See **CPS** on Page A4

WILL COUNTY

Panel split on sprawling solar farm

By Alicia Fabbre and John Lippert
FOR THE CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Plans for a solar farm that would sprawl across 45 miles of prime farmland will move to the Will County Board for a final vote without a recommendation from its land-use committee.

The board's committee deadlocked 3-3 on a vote Thursday to recommend approval of a special-use permit for Earthrise Energy's proposed development, dubbed Pride of the Prairie.

Republicans Judy Ogalla, whose district covers the proposed project area, and Raquel Mitchell were joined by Democrat Dawn Bullock in voting against the project that would cover 6,100 acres of farmland in Wilton, Green Garden and Manhattan townships. Democrats Sherry Newquist, whose district also covers a portion of the project, Herb Brooks and Destinee Ortiz voted in support.

Meanwhile, the same committee voted 4-2, with Ogalla and Mitchell voting no, to recommend approval of Earthrise's 2,400-acre Plum

Valley solar farm project in Crete Township. Both proposals will go to the county board April 16 for a final vote.

The vote on Pride of the Prairie presents a difficult choice for a board evenly split between Republicans and Democrats.

"There's going to be a lawsuit either way so you're going to have to figure out which side you are on," Jeff Becker, a Green Garden Township resident and chair of an environmental group called the

See **SOLAR** on Page A5



Will County Board members Judy Ogalla, left, and Raquel Mitchell react during a Will County Land Use and Development Committee meeting at the Renaissance Center in Joliet on Thursday. **JOSH BOLAND/TRIBUNE**

Agents spotted at courthouse

Cook County leaders decried an appearance by federal immigration agents Thursday at a domestic violence-focused courthouse, blasting the effort as a violation of state law. **Chicagoland, Page A5**

Airline covering new ground

American Airlines' new bus service helps connect passengers traveling from South Bend and Rockford to Chicago O'Hare International Airport, where they can catch flights to their final destinations. **Business**

Iran persists with air attacks

Iran fired more missiles at Israel and Gulf Arab states Thursday, demonstrating Tehran's ability to strike even as the U.S. claimed any threat from the country was nearly eliminated. **Nation & World, Page B4**

SUBSCRIPTION

Visit myaccount.chicagotribune.com or call 312-546-7900 to sign up for a subscription. To place an ad, visit placeanad.chicagotribune.com.

WEATHER FORECAST

TODAY H: 58 L: 42
SAT. H: 59 L: 36
SUN. H: 51 L: 36
Complete details on Page A12

INDEX

Almanac A9
Comics D6-D7
Crossword D7
Editorials A6
Horoscope D6
Nation & World B4
Obituaries A9
Sudoku D7
Television D5

178th year No. 93
© Chicago Tribune

